

Case Study: Motorica AG, Conflict in the Marketing Department

Opening

On a Thursday in April 2026, Jonas Weber stopped in front of the glass wall of Launch Room 4 at Motorica AG headquarters. The wall showed the timetable for the European launch of Elysion, the company's new electric SUV. Overnight, someone had placed red notes on three workstreams: campaign story, digital media testing, and dealer launch materials. The notes all pointed to the same problem. Two teams inside Jonas' marketing department had stopped coordinating effectively.

Jonas was Head of Marketing Europe at Motorica, a German car manufacturer with a strong premium heritage and an increasingly visible electric vehicle portfolio. The Elysion launch mattered beyond one model. It was meant to show that Motorica could combine engineering credibility, digital services, and an emotionally appealing electric mobility brand. The campaign also had to support DriveSphere, an AI based cockpit service that personalized route planning, charging recommendations, and in-car assistance.

By noon, Jonas had received separate calls from Anna Klein, Head of Brand Strategy, and Tobias Neumann, Head of Digital Growth. Anna argued that Tobias' team was weakening the launch by testing short, performance-oriented messages before the core brand narrative had been approved. Tobias argued that Anna's team was blocking learning and treating digital evidence as a threat to brand authority. Jonas had to decide how to intervene before the next launch steering meeting.

The department and the emerging conflict

Jonas led a marketing department of about 120 employees. Brand Strategy owned the overall campaign narrative, visual identity, agency briefing, and alignment with the global brand board. Digital Growth owned performance marketing, web analytics, paid social, search advertising, landing page optimization, and funnel reporting. Product Marketing connected both teams with engineering, sales regions, and dealer communication.

The formal plan looked straightforward. Brand Strategy would define the Elysion launch message, Digital Growth would translate it into testable digital variants, and Product Marketing would check technical accuracy. In practice, the sequence became contested. Brand Strategy wanted the campaign to begin with a carefully staged premium story: quiet power, German precision, and digital confidence. Digital Growth wanted to test several messages early because search behavior and social media data suggested that many prospective customers first asked practical questions about charging, software reliability, and total cost of ownership.

The conflict intensified after Finance reduced the launch budget by 12 percent. Anna interpreted the budget cut as a reason to protect the coherence of the campaign. In her view, a smaller budget required stronger discipline, fewer variants, and clearer control over the message. Tobias interpreted the same budget cut in the opposite way. For him, a smaller budget made experimentation more important because the department could not afford to spend heavily on untested assumptions.

The first open clash occurred in a Monday launch meeting. Anna showed three polished storyboards from the lead agency. Tobias interrupted after the second storyboard and asked why no data from the pre-launch search tests had been incorporated. Anna replied that the tests were premature because the campaign idea had not been approved. Tobias responded: "If we wait until everything is approved, digital learning becomes decoration." Anna answered: "If every dashboard changes the story, Motorica will look like a discount brand testing slogans in public."

Competing interpretations

Jonas initially saw a task conflict about how to divide launch work. Yet it was also a resource conflict because both teams competed for budget, agency time, and senior attention. It was a status conflict because Brand Strategy had traditionally been closer to the executive board, while Digital Growth had gained visibility through measurable campaign effects. It was a political conflict because each team tried to define which evidence should count in launch decisions.

The informal organization made the conflict harder to manage. Brand Strategy controlled access to the lead agency and the global brand board. Digital Growth controlled dashboard data that the CFO and regional sales leaders increasingly requested. Product Marketing often acted as translator, but it had limited authority. Several employees avoided joint meetings and instead sent comments through Jonas' office. A senior brand manager privately told Jonas: "If Digital wants to run the launch, they should also carry the reputation risk." A digital campaign analyst wrote in a chat: "Brand asks for evidence only after the decision is already made."

Jonas had four intervention options. He could decide the campaign logic himself and impose a sequence. He could ask both team leads to negotiate a shared process. He could create an escalation committee with Product Marketing, Sales, and Finance. Or he could redesign the launch process so that brand approval, digital testing, and technical validation were explicitly connected. Each option carried risks. A top-down decision might create compliance without cooperation. A negotiated compromise might reproduce the same status dynamics. A committee could slow down the launch. A process redesign could be seen as too heavy for an urgent campaign.

Decision point

The next launch steering meeting was scheduled for Friday morning. Jonas needed a conflict handling concept that would reduce escalation, protect the launch timetable, and preserve useful disagreement. He also had to decide whether the conflict should be treated as a personality issue between Anna and Tobias, a structural issue in the marketing process, or a broader informal organization problem involving status, resources, power, and competing norms of evidence.

Your group task

You are advising Jonas Weber, Head of Marketing Europe at Motorica AG. Your group works on this case only. Prepare a 3 to 5 minute presentation with 2 to 3 slides. Use evidence from the case and end with a concrete recommendation that Jonas could implement before the next launch meeting.

1. What kind of conflict is this? Distinguish task, relationship, status, resource, and political dimensions.
2. Which informal sources of power shape the conflict between Brand Strategy and Digital Growth?
3. What should Jonas do next? Develop a conflict handling concept that specifies the next steps.

Disclaimer

This teaching case is fictional and intended solely for classroom use. Generative AI has been used to develop and refine this case.